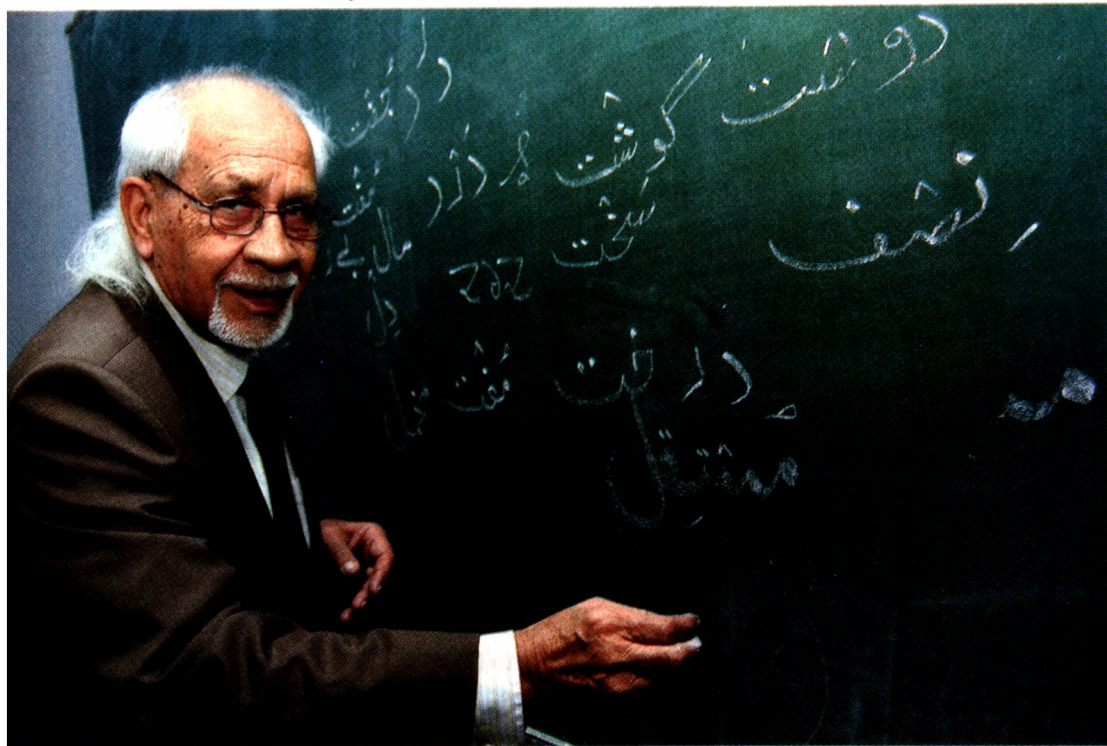


Couplet Reader

A passionate old man has taught Urdu for 34 years to doctors, policemen and shopkeepers, all for a paltry sum



TEACHING URDU IS LALL'S MISSION

By Arvind Chhabra

It is an unusual evening class at SD College in Chandigarh's Sector 32. The students are officers, shopkeepers and policemen who learn Urdu from a retired government employee at a college which is better known for commerce. The frail but enthusiastic teacher, H.K. Lall, 73, ensures that each of his nearly one dozen students remains entertained, thanks to the lovely language that Urdu is and the captivating couplets he keeps throwing in. The wiry old man has done this for 34 years now but gets just Rs 500 as a monthly remuneration. That is the amount the Punjab Languages Department pays him and other part-time teachers, which is a fraction of what the departmental peon gets. "Earlier I used to get Rs 100 and in those days they would deduct Rs 3.30 for each class one missed," recalls Lall.

The course is called *amoz*, which means preliminary. Students don't pay a penny and anyone can enrol for the classes. He has taught top officers, doctors, policemen and even *panwaris* (cigarette sellers). The policemen and

tehsildars learn Urdu as part of their professional duty while others do it as they want to savour ghazals better. But interest in the language has dwindled. Earlier, he used to get almost 40-45 students. "I don't expect everyone to become an Urdu scholar, but I want all the people to know a bit of the language because it's amazing."

For Lall, Urdu was never a profession. It is a passion that turned into an obsession and is now a mission. The atheist says: "It is my *waalihana aqeedat* (divine faith). No language can be confined to a religion or community." He was employed with the Punjab Irrigation Department for over 38 years but never thought of it as a career. He has no regrets. "No work, no mistake was my philosophy. I used to teach then also and many of my seniors were my students. So I could afford not to work," he quips. Punjab Finance Minister Manpreet Badal promised to raise the remuneration to Rs 2,500 but that remains a promise. Lall remains unruffled. "I have laughed away half of my life and smoked away the rest." Truly, he's in love with language and life. ■